

Chapter 147_1 - Turning Point

After finishing her words, she placed the half-completed embroidery on the table and slipped out of Ning Fuyi's embrace like a fish that had just emerged from water.

Ning Fuyi stuck out her tongue, knowing she had said the wrong thing. She quickly picked up the embroidery and chased after her: "It's my poor eyesight. Actually, looking closely, I can still make out the mandarin ducks..."

"Chu Qingqiu, Qiuqiu¹, Qiu'er², don't go!"

...

The days they spent together always passed extremely quickly. Time was like fine sand that couldn't be grasped, flowing endlessly through their fingers until it was all gone, leaving not even dust in their palms.

No matter how much they treasured it, the inevitable day still arrived cruelly.

The previous night had moon-white light like silk and stars filling the sky, so that day should have been a bright, sunny day. Yet Ning Fuyi was awakened at dawn by a tremendous crash. When she rolled out of bed and landed on the ground, she could see that blazing hot flames had already ignited outside the barrier overhead.

Throughout Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, fearful screams rose and fell everywhere. The younger disciples had already been ordered not to leave their rooms, while the remaining senior disciples all ran outside, using their immortal power to reinforce the overhead barrier.

A white-robed figure swept past Ning Fuyi's side. She quickly shouted Chu Qingqiu's name and flashed into a stream of light, chasing after her outside.

"Divine Venerable!" Elder Pingyao came running with stumbling steps. Panic showed on her usually composed face as she shook her head continuously: "Penglai has sent Limitless Ghost Fire down upon Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. Though our barrier can hold for a while, the disciples' immortal power will eventually be exhausted."

"When the barrier is broken, we're all dead!"

Chu Qingqiu frowned and looked up to see the vast barrier overhead covered in flames. This fire was white as snow without any smoke, but it turned the entire Cloud Ascension Mountain into a steamer - one could feel their skin parching even from far away.

Elder Jingshan also came running breathlessly, so anxious his clothing was disheveled: "Elder Pingyao, this can't continue. Why don't we have the disciples flee elsewhere first - at least they could survive..."

"Absolutely not!" Elder Pingyao angrily rebuked in a thunderous voice: "We can flee, but what about the common people at the foot of the mountain and the living beings in the mountains? This ghost fire seems to target Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, but once the barrier breaks, Cloud Ascension Mountain will become a sea of fire. Dianxing³ Town and the villages at the foot of the mountain will also be doomed!"

"How could we take tens of thousands of ordinary people away? And where could we find a place to settle them? Without homes, water, and food, even if we brought everyone out, only a dead end would await them."

The various immortal sects had already laid down formation barriers throughout the mortal realm during these days, hoping to resist the ghost fire when it fell. But Limitless Ghost Fire couldn't be extinguished or smothered - no method could address the root of the problem.

"Then can we only endure like this now?" Elder Jingshan anxiously beat his fists.

Though Elder Pingyao was equally panicked, she quickly spoke in a deep voice: "Have all disciples do their utmost to reinforce the barrier, and send people to request help from other sects. No matter what, we must protect Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate and preserve Cloud Ascension Mountain."

Elder Jingshan could only agree and ran off in great haste to gather the Eastern Courtyard disciples in the mountain gate.

"Divine Venerable..." Only then did Elder Pingyao remember Chu Qingqiu and quickly bowed her head.

"It's fine. You've done well," Chu Qingqiu sensed her meaning and spoke: "At this time, aside from protecting Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, there's no other way."

As the two spoke, another ball of fire fell from overhead. The flames thundered down, shaking the barrier until it looked like a giant soap bubble, showing transparent concave depressions.

Screams rose around them again, and at this time more disciples awakened from their sleep and joined the ranks of those protecting the barrier.

One could see immortal power of various colors surging everywhere from peak to mountainside, forming bands of light that fed into the barrier - a truly spectacular scene.

Chu Qingqiu gazed up at the constantly fluctuating barrier, those blinding lights continuously reflecting in her eyes.

"Chu Qingqiu..." Ning Fuyi felt a wave of despair surge in her heart and reached out to grasp her sleeve.

Chu Qingqiu turned back and reached up to touch the back of her head, rubbing those loose hairs: "Don't be afraid. Let's focus on maintaining the barrier first."

Ning Fuyi watched her figure, unable to speak. She knew that even if she spoke, it wouldn't be of any use.

She couldn't stop anything.

Ning Fuyi suddenly felt hostility surge in her heart. She looked up fiercely at the constantly bombarded barrier, then placed her palms together before spreading them like an umbrella, overlapping her thumbs, then pulling her hands apart.

Rich, dazzling pink light gathered in her palms, finally shooting into the air with a low shout, becoming the thickest beam of light in the mountains. When the pink light touched the barrier, the entire barrier was tinted with a faint color.

Crackling lightning gathered in the thin immortal power, causing everyone to look in her direction with amazement.

"Who is that?" Feng Ge and Hong Ying, standing atop Zhuguan Pavilion, were distracted by that beam of light illuminating the mountain peak: "Using immortal power like this - does she not want to live?"

Liu Wenzhu, who had rushed out of Zhuguan Pavilion, looked up and immediately recognized whose light this was. She anxiously turned to rush toward Jingshan Palace but was pulled back by Hua Feihua.

"Look," Hua Feihua raised her hand toward the uninhabited western area, where the barrier had become extremely weak without anyone controlling it. Raging flames devoured the barrier thin as cicada wings and were about to burn a hole through it.

"Protecting the barrier comes first!" Hua Feihua patted Liu Wenzhu's shoulder, then straightened and ran toward that area.

Liu Wenzhu hesitated in place for a moment, then worriedly looked back once more before steeling herself to turn and follow Hua Feihua's footsteps.

Seeing this, Chu Qingqiu was naturally shocked. She quickly reached for Ning Fuyi's arm, trying to make her withdraw her immortal power: "What are you doing? Do you want to repair the barrier all by yourself?"

However, Ning Fuyi didn't let go. Instead, she turned sideways to shake off her arm and continued to pour out immortal power endlessly.

As long as the barrier didn't break, as long as they protected the mortal realm and the ghost fire didn't spread, Chu Qingqiu wouldn't have to die.

So even if her immortal power was exhausted, it didn't matter.

Chu Qingqiu couldn't make her stop by calling or pulling. Finally, she pressed her thin lips lightly together and stood shoulder to shoulder with her, releasing equally magnificent immortal power from her bones.

Thus the barrier covering the nearby mountains and rivers became several times more solid. Pink and white were clearly distinct, finally resembling a Bagua⁴ formation that almost blocked out even the sunlight.

Within the barrier, the wind seemed to stand still, so quiet that even the tree shadows remained motionless.

Others in the sect stopped in amazement. Feng Ge nearly fell from the rooftop in anxiety, saying repeatedly: "That immortal power belongs to the Divine Venerable. It's one thing for Ning Fuyi to act recklessly, but how can the Divine Venerable follow her in such folly!"

"Exactly," Hong Ying, seeing his immortal power had little effect, lowered his hands and stretched to peer at the brilliant Jingshan Palace: "At the rate the Divine Venerable and she are using it, even a True God's cultivation wouldn't last more than a few hours!"

After speaking, he looked down at the disciples gathered in groups below: "Tao Tao, Li Yang, go to Xuanliang Garden to help Rong Jin protect the Northern Courtyard disciples. The rest of you, follow me to the front of Cloud Deep Hall."

"Conserve your energy and prepare for battle. If the barrier shows the slightest loosening, we'll all resist together!"

The remaining disciples all obeyed orders and disappeared with him, heading to Cloud Deep Hall, which was closest to the barrier.

On Ning Fuyi's side, she couldn't hear others' amazement. She was single-mindedly focused on blocking the ghost fire, willing to exhaust her immortal power completely.

Footnotes:

1. **Qiuqiu (秋秋)** - An affectionate nickname formed by repeating part of Chu Qingqiu's name
2. **Qiu'er (秋儿)** - Another affectionate diminutive of her name
3. **Dianxing (点星)** - Literally "point star"; the name of the town at the foot of the mountain
4. **Bagua (八卦)** - The Eight Trigrams, a fundamental concept in Chinese philosophy and divination, often represented as an octagonal symbol